itself.” Gleason also denied that there is any endpoint or climax community; he believed that communities are always changing.



Diseases such as American chestnut blight challenge the idea of a fully integrated climax community, as the loss of the dominant tree species should cause the entire ecosystem to collapse.

Changing opinions

Gleason’s argument with Clements caused quite a stir at the time. Clements seemed to be creating an overview in which natural patterns of vegetation were determined by clear rules, just as in Newtonian science the movement of the planets is dictated by incontrovertible laws. Clements and his supporters were able to look at the bigger picture, while Gleason was